FOR INDIA TO GET BETTER

India's path to becoming a global powerhouse hinges on the well-being of its people. Addressing the dual challenges of rising noncommunicable diseases and an ageing population is essential for sustainable economic growth and prosperity

By **Sonali Acharjee**

The health of India's vast populace is, of course, important for its own sake. It is also a critical component of rapid growth—think of it as the cause, not the effect, of India becoming a global giant. A healthy workforce will be the life-force of our economy. The challenges before us are stark. While making health accessible and affordable to the masses is critical, there has to be a major emphasis on tackling the new epidemic of lifestyle diseases that are classified as noncommunicable diseases (NCDs).

According to a World Health Organization (WHO) report titled 'Invisible Numbers', a staggering 66 per cent of deaths in India in 2019 were attributed to NCDs: high blood pressure, cancer, heart disease, diabetes, lung disease, stroke, renal disease and mental disorders. The report suggests that 22 per cent of Indians then at age 30 or more would succumb to these before their 70th birthday. In 2017, the Indian Council of Medical Research, too, had estimated that the share of deaths due to NCDs in India increased from 37.9 per cent in 1990 to 61.8 per cent in 2016. "Not only is the financial strain of treating NCDs higher, so are the mortality rates," says Dr Dorairaj Prabhakaran, noted cardiologist and Executive Director, Centre for Chronic Disease Control. He also cites the reduction in quality of life that patients suffer. "Unlike an infectious disease, NCDs stay with you for life and need vigilant monitoring and medicine," adds Dr Prabhakaran.

On top of the rising burden of NCDs, there is also a prediction that a large elderly population's health needs will be specific and call for long-term structures to be put in place. India's current elderly population of 153 million (aged 60 and above) is expected to more than double to 347 million by 2050, according to the United Nations Population Fund. "We must invest in geriatric care. Their health needs are different and they need as much mental and emotional care as they do for physical diseases. We will also need a stronger emergency response system," says Dr Vishal Sehgal, president of home medical care firm Portea Medical, more than 60 per cent of whose services are availed by the elderly. This double whammy of rising NCDs and geriatric health issues has experts convinced that the country must lose no time to build up its infrastructure and improve the costing of healthcare. "The current system will not be able to cope with the rising caseloads. We either need new hospitals or must expand existing ones," says Dr Sumanth C. Raman, author of *Sick Business: the Truth behind Healthcare in India*.

PRIORITISING DIAGNOSTICS

Experts say diagnostic upgrades should be the first priority, as they will help prevent diseases, including infectious ones, in the first place. "Today, diagnostics is key for treatment outcomes. If diseases are caught in time, the recovery is better and NCDs can even be reversed, saving health and finance," says Dr Randeep Guleria, former director of AIIMS, New Delhi. This is already happening for tuberculosis, which the country is trying hard to eliminate. "Now, there is a focus on bringing diagnostics to the primary healthcare level. India

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